the vaccine credibility made a larger dent to the country on the international stage. When Bharat Biotech applied for Emergency Use Listing from the WHO, the latter took an unusually long time in granting it. Krishna Ella, Bharat Biotech's chairman, a few weeks after WHO's approval in a Times Now Conclave, expressed his frustration with the Opposition ecosystem by saying,

> The way anti-things happen, that has hurt us more. If someone wants to take on the political system they can take on different angles, but not on the healthcare issues. When Prime Minister took the vaccine, immediately they said it's a BJP vaccine, it's a Modi vaccine. All sorts of synonyms. I want people to realise instead of criticising just ask us, we will tell the truth. But making own opinion that hurt us very badly. The negative things said put the WHO too in an awkward position. They wanted to be doubly sure and reviewed our vaccine much more intensively. We are scientists, we don't understand the politics. We are the only vaccine in the WHO who've gone through so much scrutiny.[12]



16 JANUARY 2021

INDIA | 2,09,158 ACTIVE CASES | 1,53,368 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,83,23,340 ACTIVE CASES | 21,46,252 DEATHS

Two weeks following the approval for the emergency use authorization of Covishield and Covaxin were spent in preparing adequate distribution of the available stockpiled vaccines to all states and UTs so that India's vaccine drive could commence. The first phase of the drive would cover doctors, nurses, frontline workers like the police, the Armed Forces and other healthcare workers—totalling to about three crore people. The GoI would pay the cost of the vaccines in full for this group. The prime minister flagged off the vaccine drive, after which he tweeted, 'On 16th January, India takes a landmark step forward in fighting COVID-19. Starting that day, India's nationwide vaccination drive begins. Priority will be given to our brave doctors, healthcare workers, frontline workers including safai karamcharis (cleaners).'[13]